

UI / UX

Monday, 21 September 2026

10:06 pm

- UI/UX Design Fundamentals (LinkedIn Learning, or an equivalent course)
- UX Foundations: Prototyping and Wireframing (Figma / Adobe XD)
- Figma or Balsamiq Essential Training (pick a wireframing tool)
- User Experience (UX) for Non-Designers or Product Managers
- Design Thinking: Understanding the Customer Journey

Introduction to Web Design and Development

Understanding UX and Website Planning

User Experience (UX) focuses on how easily and effectively people interact with a product or service, from finding information to completing tasks.

1.  **Focus on users** – Understand user needs, goals, behaviours, and problems to create simple and effective experiences.
2.  **Plan and organize information** – UX professionals structure content and workflows so users can easily find what they need.
3.  **Prototype and test** – Create prototypes and test them with users to identify and remove usability problems before development.
4.  **Different UX roles** – UX generalists cover the full process, while specialists focus on areas such as user research, information architecture, testing, branding, or content design.
5.  **Collaborate frequently** – UX professionals work closely with users, managers, and developers and need to communicate ideas clearly.
6.  **Use UX tools** – Common tools include **Figma, Sketch, Adobe XD, InVision, and Balsamiq**, along with methods such as workflows and sticky-note mapping.

Key takeaway: UX is about **understanding users, simplifying their interactions, testing ideas, and continuously improving the experience** through research and collaboration.

Understanding User Interface (UI) Design

UI design focuses on the **customer-facing interface** of websites and applications. UI designers connect UX research, visual design, and programming.

1.  **Focus on the interface** – Design the front end that users interact with, including layouts, visuals, and animations.
2.  **Combine design and coding** – Common skills include **HTML, CSS, JavaScript**, and basic programming knowledge.
3.  **Use design and development tools** – Tools may include **Figma, Adobe XD, VS Code, Git, GitHub, and Node.js**.
4.  **Bridge different teams** – Work closely with UX researchers, graphic designers, and developers to turn research and designs into working interfaces.
5.  **Communicate and collaborate** – UI designers participate in handoff meetings, focused design/coding work, and feedback sessions.

Key takeaway: UI design combines **design, technology, and user experience** to create functional and visually effective interfaces that users can easily interact with.

Prototyping Tools

Prototyping tools help teams quickly create and modify models of a future product **without writing code**, making it easier to test ideas and gather user feedback.

1.  **Build and change quickly** – Prototypes can be created, tested, measured, and updated through multiple iterations.
2.  **Use drag-and-drop components** – Tools provide ready-made elements such as buttons, forms, navigation bars, images, and icons.

3.  **Create interactive prototypes** – Screens can be linked together with interactions and simple animations to simulate a real product.
4.  **Figma for UI/UX design** – Figma allows teams to design interfaces, create prototypes, share work, and collaborate.
5.  **FigJam for planning** – FigJam supports whiteboarding, sticky notes, diagrams, customer journey maps, flowcharts, and brainstorming.

Key takeaway: Prototyping tools like **Figma** and **FigJam** help teams design, test, collaborate, and iterate quickly before investing time and resources into development.

Graphic Design Tools

Graphic designers use different tools depending on whether they are creating **illustrations, photos, UI designs, or quick graphics**.

1.  **Adobe Illustrator** – Used for illustrations and logos. Creates **vector graphics** that can scale without losing quality, often exported as SVG.
2.  **Adobe Photoshop** – Used for photo editing and **raster graphics** made from pixels, commonly exported as PNG, JPEG, or GIF.
3.  **Affinity Designer & Photo** – More affordable alternatives to Illustrator and Photoshop, with simpler interfaces and essential design features.
4.  **Figma** – Mainly a prototyping and UI design tool, but also useful for creating basic graphics and logos.
5.  **Canva** – Beginner-friendly tool with templates, colour palettes, and simple design features for creating professional-looking graphics quickly.

Key takeaway: Choose tools based on your needs—**Illustrator** for **vector graphics**, **Photoshop** for **photos**, **Figma** for **UI/prototyping**, and **Canva** for **simple, quick designs**.

What is Design Thinking?

Design thinking is a customer-focused approach that helps teams understand user problems, generate creative solutions, and test ideas through prototypes.

1.  **Focus on users** – Understand products and services from the customer's perspective.
2.  **Encourage creativity** – Help teams explore innovative solutions to important user problems.
3.  **Prototype and test** – Build and test ideas quickly before investing heavily in development.
4.  **Gain stakeholder support** – Encourage buy-in and help technical, business, and design teams understand user needs.
5.  **Support Agile & Lean** – Design thinking complements Agile and Lean approaches by focusing on learning, experimentation, and delivering useful solutions.

Key takeaway: Design thinking helps organizations **understand users, solve the right problems, generate creative ideas, and test solutions quickly** before implementation.

Agile, Lean, and Design Thinking

These three approaches work together to **develop useful products faster and reduce wasted effort**.

1.  **Design Thinking** – Brings business, technology, and users together to understand real user needs, create solutions, and test ideas before investing heavily in development.
2.  **Lean** – Tests ideas quickly, uses feedback to identify what provides business value, and determines what to work on next.
3.  **Agile** – Builds and tests solutions through short iterations, using learning and feedback to continuously improve the product.
4.  **How they connect** – Design Thinking can act as a starting point for Lean and Agile by combining early research, hypothesis testing, and initial iterations.

Key takeaway: **Design Thinking** discovers the right problem and solution, **Lean** tests business value, and **Agile** builds and improves the solution quickly.

Design Thinking – Who's Involved & What It Achieves

Who's Involved?

Design thinking should involve **representatives from different disciplines** to bring diverse perspectives and create shared understanding.

- **Core team:** Business, IT, marketing, legal, design, user research, testing, and operations.
- **Specialists:** Technical architects, localization/internationalization, legal, and other experts can join regular demos

or provide input when needed.

-  **Benefit:** Early collaboration reduces misunderstandings and prevents repeated meetings later in the project.

What Design Thinking Helps Achieve

1.  **Customer-centered solutions** – Identify and solve real customer pain points.
2.  **Faster iteration** – Start the build–test–learn cycle earlier and prioritize ideas that provide early value.
3.  **Shared understanding** – Ensure everyone understands what is being built, why, and their role in delivering it.
4.  **Better prioritization** – Focus on customer needs and business value while avoiding unnecessary “pet features.”
5.  **Validate the right solution** – Regular customer interaction helps confirm whether the team is building the right thing and allows corrections early.

Key takeaway: Design thinking brings diverse teams together around **customer needs**, helping them build the right solution, prioritize effectively, and learn early through continuous customer feedback.

What Is Real Design Thinking

An effective **design thinking** should go beyond attractive concepts and sketches. It should lead to something the development team can actually build and test.

1.  **Avoid concept-only design** – Sketches and storyboards are not enough; teams need priorities, dependencies, milestones, and an implementation plan.
2.  **Validate with customers** – Test prototypes and gather feedback throughout development, from early prototypes to post-release products.
3.  **Involve the whole team** – Business, product, development, testing, operations, design, and research should participate from the beginning.
4.  **Design thinking = design doing** – The process should produce a **verified prototype and realistic project plan**, not just impressive presentations.
5.  **Focus on the customer** – Collaboration across disciplines helps teams understand customer needs and turn user research into valuable solutions.
6.  **Expect commitment** – Effective design thinking requires concentrated effort, collaboration, and breaking down barriers between different roles.

Key takeaway: Real design thinking is about **turning customer insights into tested, practical, and implementable solutions—not just creating attractive concepts.**

Finding the Real Problem

Design thinking starts by **understanding the customer’s real problems** through direct observation and conversations.

1.  **Observe real users** – Watch customers perform real tasks and discuss their experiences instead of relying only on assumptions, statistics, or surveys.
2.  **Identify pain points** – Turn customer insights into a prioritized list of problems and goals for the product.
3.  **Set measurable goals** – Define metrics early to determine whether the project is actually delivering customer and business value.
4.  **Explore multiple ideas** – Avoid jumping to the first solution. Generate and build on different ideas from across the team.
5.  **Involve everyone** – Encourage people from different disciplines to participate in ideation. Diverse perspectives can create more creative solutions and shared ownership.

Key takeaway: Start with **real customer problems**, then use collaborative ideation to explore creative solutions rather than assuming the first idea is the right one.

Iterative Design Thinking & Development

Design thinking works best when teams can **measure, learn, and change direction** instead of being locked into an initial plan.

1.  **Test and adapt** – Use Lean/Agile iterations to test ideas, learn from failures, and make quick course corrections.
2.  **Reduce risk early** – Prototypes, testing, clear goals, metrics, and technical involvement help identify problems before major development begins.
3.  **Communicate continuously** – Use artifacts such as experience maps, prototypes, story maps, and storyboards to clearly communicate decisions and progress.
4.  **Deliver value sooner** – Iterative development releases the most important, high-value features first rather than waiting for the entire product to be completed.
5.  **Avoid unnecessary work** – Continuous customer feedback helps teams identify which features are valuable

and avoid building features customers don't need.

6. 🌐 **Support remote teams** – Design artifacts give distributed teams clear context about customer problems, intended interactions, and how their work fits into the overall product.

Key takeaway: Design thinking combined with **Lean/Agile iteration** helps teams reduce risk, deliver valuable features faster, learn from customers, and communicate effectively across teams.

🧑 **Summary: Guerilla Design Thinking**

Guerilla design thinking means **starting small, demonstrating results, and using success to build organizational support** rather than waiting for formal approval.

1. 🚀 **Just start** – Run a 1–2 week design thinking workshop on a project and demonstrate the results through real experience.
2. 🗨️ **Get key people on board** – Identify influential, open-minded people from different departments and explain how design thinking can solve their specific frustrations.
3. 🧩 **Break down silos** – Bring business, legal, marketing, operations, developers, and planners together early to improve communication, estimates, and decision-making.
4. 📅 **Track the journey** – Document research, sketches, prototypes, alpha builds, releases, and customer feedback to show how the product evolved.
5. 📊 **Measure the impact** – Collect **quantitative data** such as customer satisfaction, retention, costs, and support savings, as well as **qualitative feedback** such as customer and team quotes.
6. 📢 **Share success stories** – Use the project's results and evidence to demonstrate the value of design thinking and encourage wider adoption.
7. 💡 **Reduce resistance** – Explain how involving everyone early can reduce unnecessary meetings, improve communication, identify issues sooner, and produce better estimates.
8. 🐎 **Use it as a "Trojan horse"** – Once teams see the benefits, introduce other user-centered techniques such as usability testing, content testing, information architecture research, and field research.

Key takeaway: Start small, prove the value with real results, and use successful projects to gradually build a **customer-focused design culture** across the organization.